The balloon itself

Edition Oct 2026

Aboard every flight

- **Airworthiness certificate**, displayed at the entrance where passengers or crew can read it (91.203(a)(1), (b)).
- **Registration certificate.** It expires 7 years after the last day of the month it was issued (91.203(a)(2); 47.40).
- **Operating limitations** in the Balloon Flight Manual or on a placard the pilot can see, and you fly within them (31.81(b); 91.9).

Required instruments (31.85)

Every balloon
Altimeter
Rate-of-climb indicator

Hot air adds
Fuel quantity gauge (each fuel cell)
Envelope temperature indicator

Captive gas adds
Compass

Inspections (91.409)

Inspection	Needed when	Interval
Annual	Every flight	Within the preceding **12 calendar months**
100-hour (an annual also satisfies it)	Carrying anyone other than crew for hire, or giving flight instruction for hire in a balloon you provide	Within the preceding **100 h** time in service. Up to 10 h over only to reach the inspection, and those hours count toward the next 100.

Who answers for what

- **Owner or operator:** keeps the balloon airworthy, including airworthiness directives (91.403(a)), and keeps records of the work, its date, and the signature and certificate number of whoever approved return to service; total time; inspection status; and each AD's number, revision date, method of compliance and next due time (91.417).
- **Pilot in command:** decides it is in condition for safe flight, and ends the flight if it becomes unairworthy (91.7).
- **Preventive maintenance a pilot may do** on a balloon the pilot owns or operates (43.3(g); a sport pilot only on a light-sport category aircraft): small envelope fabric repairs not needing load tape repair or replacement, per the manufacturer; cleaning burner pilot and main nozzles; swapping baskets and burners the type certificate data lists as interchangeable and that are designed for quick removal and installation (Part 43 App. A). Record it: what was done, the date, and your signature, certificate number and kind of certificate (43.9(a)).

Airplane rules that do not apply

91.205 instruments	Powered aircraft only
91.207 ELT	Airplanes only
91.151 fuel reserve	Airplanes and rotorcraft only. Plan propane under 91.103 and your flight manual.
91.107 belt briefing and use	A free balloon with a basket or gondola is excepted
91.215 and 91.225	Only partly: see the radio card

Sources: 14 CFR 31.81, 14 CFR 31.85, 14 CFR 43.9(a), 14 CFR 43.3(g), 14 CFR Part 43 Appendix A(c), 14 CFR 47.40, 14 CFR 91.7, 14 CFR 91.9, 14 CFR 91.107, 14 CFR 91.151, 14 CFR 91.203, 14 CFR 91.205, 14 CFR 91.207, 14 CFR 91.403, 14 CFR 91.409, 14 CFR 91.417. Original card, not an FAA document. Study aid, not for navigation.